

TIOBE INDEX

MARCH 2026

TIOBE Index March 2026: How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

Programming Language Popularity Rankings &
Trends

Source: TIOBE Software | Captured April 10, 2026

Audience: Software Engineering Leads & Technology Strategists

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

Rank '26	Rank '25	Language	Rating	YoY Change
1	1	Python	21.25%	-2.59%
2	4	C	11.55%	+2.02%
3	2	C++	8.18%	-2.90%
4	3	Java	7.99%	-2.37%
5	5	C#	6.36%	+1.49%
6	6	JavaScript	3.45%	-0.01%
7	9	Visual Basic	2.50%	-0.02%
8	8	SQL	2.00%	-0.57%
9	16	R	1.88%	+0.94%
10	10	Delphi/Object Pascal	1.80%	-0.36%
11	24	Perl	1.75%	+1.05%
12	12	Scratch	1.63%	-0.03%
13	11	Fortran	1.45%	-0.25%
14	14	Rust	1.31%	+0.09%
15	15	MATLAB	1.29%	+0.31%
16	7	Go	1.29%	-1.49%
17	17	Assembly language	1.29%	+0.42%
18	13	PHP	1.23%	-0.25%
19	18	Ada	1.10%	+0.25%

Source: TIOBE Software, March 2026

Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 -- The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

▲ GAINERS

Perl

24th → 11th

+1.05% rating

+13 spots

R

16th → 9th

+0.94% rating

+7 spots

Swift

26th → 20th

+0.44% rating

+6 spots

C

4th → 2nd

+2.02% rating

+2 spots

▼ LOSERS

Go

7th → 16th

-1.49% rating

-9 spots

PHP

13th → 18th

-0.25% rating

-5 spots

Fortran

11th → 13th

-0.25% rating

-2 spots

C++

2nd → 3rd

-2.90% rating

-1 spot

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

Language	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991	1986
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17	-	-
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2	2	9
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31	-	-
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11	-	-	-
JavaScript	6	7	8	10	10	8	33	-	-
Go	10	11	60	16	-	-	-	-	-
Ada	14	36	25	22	16	18	6	10	3
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8	4	2



Python's Meteoric Rise

Unranked before 1991. Entered top 30 by 2001. Reached #1 by 2026 — a 25-year climb.

#1

C: The Only Constant

C has held top-2 across all nine measurement points spanning four decades.



Lisp's Long Decline

#2 in 1986, now ranked 26th. Java dominated 2005–2018 before falling below 8%.

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times -- More Than Any Other Language

2025 C#	2024 Python	2023 C#
2022 C++	2021 Python	2020 Python
2019 C	2018 Python	2016 Go

6x

Python won Language of the Year

(2007 2010 2018 2020 2021 2024)

C# Won Twice Recently

2023 & 2025 — driven by .NET ecosystem growth

Go's 2016 Win ≠ Current Status

Language of the Year 2016, but now dropped to 16th in 2026

The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

1

Python Dominates But Is Declining

At 21.25% (>2× the #2 language), yet posted the largest YoY drop among top 5 at -2.59 pp. Monitor trajectory before doubling down on Python-only hiring.

2

C's Resurgence Demands Attention

Climbed from 4th to 2nd with +2.02 pp gain. Systems, embedded, and performance-critical teams should factor in renewed interest.

3

Legacy Languages Are Back

Perl (+13 spots to 11th), R (+7 spots to 9th), and Fortran (top 15) show entrenched scientific/infrastructure communities remain active. Don't deprioritize support prematurely.

4

Go's Sharp Decline Is a Signal

Dropped from 7th to 16th (-1.49 pp) — the largest drop in the top 20. Rust (14th, +0.09%) may be displacing Go in systems programming. Evaluate this in hiring and tooling decisions.

5

Concentration Risk Is Real

Python + C + C++ + Java = 48.97% of the index. Betting heavily on only these four creates vendor/talent risk if any major shift occurs (cf. Java's fall from 25%+ to under 8%).